was a good chance we wouldn't have to bat again. It was this thought that prompted me to stop for a moment and take in the crowd and raise my bat to them for all their support and encouragement. But the disappointment was still very much with me as I walked up the steps to the dressing room. I knew I had missed out on a big one.

As he had in Kolkata, Rohit Sharma batted exceptionally well and his second consecutive ton, as well as 113 from Pujara, helped us to a total of 495 and a lead of 313. In their second innings, the West Indies top order fell without offering much resistance. At one point the crowd was actually cheering for Chris Gayle. They wanted the game to go on so that I could bat one more time! It was funny and unreal at the same time.

By the end of the second day it was fairly clear that we would win by an innings and that 16 November 2013 would be my last day as an Indian cricketer.

16 November 2013, day three of the final Test

The West Indies started the day at 43–3 and were soon 89–6. It was at the fall of the seventh wicket that I started to feel that there wasn't long to go. Each wicket was bringing the final moment nearer. A quest of twenty-four years was about to come to an end.

When the ninth wicket fell and I ran in to congratulate the bowler, Dhoni asked me to stay away because the team was planning something. I went and stood next to the square-leg umpire while the rest were all huddling in the middle. I could not stop myself from getting emotional. It was all ending so quickly.

Within a few overs the final moment came. Mohammed Shami took the final wicket with a full delivery that knocked out Shannon Gabriel's middle stump. I rushed in again from my fielding position and picked up a stump, saying to one of my team-mates '*Yeh stump to mujhe chahiye hi chahiye.*' (I want this stump at any cost.) But again Dhoni asked if I could stand apart for a while because they had planned something special.

I stood at the other end of the pitch while the rest of the team finalized the plan. Then Ravi Shastri walked across the ground to do his television broadcast. He congratulated me on my career and said some very kind things about my contribution to the game. I was still just about holding myself together. Then the team started another guard of honour, only this